

A Note on Invoking Indo-Scandinavian Cultural Affinity for Increased Cooperation

Leveraging Proto-Indo-European Connections for 21st-Century Partnership

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Abstract

The North-Germanic and Indo-Aryan branches of the Proto-Indo-European (PIE) language family share a remarkable density of cognates, parallel mythological motifs, and comparable social structures that have fascinated linguists since 1786. This paper argues that the Indo-Scandinavian linguistic connection represents an underutilized foundation for cultural diplomacy between India and the Nordic states. We present a four-phase framework for narrative development, institutional partnership, economic collaboration, and symbolic integration that could transform a 4,500-year-old shared linguistic heritage into a durable strategic relationship. While cultural affinity cannot determine procurement outcomes or guarantee specific economic results, we argue it can provide political sustainability and public legitimacy for partnerships that serve mutual strategic interests. Drawing on precedents from cultural diplomacy initiatives worldwide, we suggest that modest, sustained investment in Indo-Nordic cultural programming (estimated \$250–350 million over 2026–2030) could materially strengthen bilateral relations and create conditions favorable to expanded cooperation across multiple domains.

Keywords: Proto-Indo-European, linguistic affinity, cultural proximity, cooperation and culture, Vedic Sanskrit

1 Introduction

When William Jones delivered his Third Anniversary Discourse to the Asiatic Society in 1786, declaring that Sanskrit, Greek, and Latin must have “sprung from some common source, which, perhaps, no longer exists,”¹ he established the foundation for comparative Indo-European studies. Two centuries of scholarship have revealed that among the most linguistically intimate branches of this family are Vedic Sanskrit and Old Norse: two cultures separated by millennia and thousands of kilometers, yet preserving strikingly similar vocabulary in domains of kinship, mythology, and social organization.[7]

¹Jones ([1]), *Asiatick Researches* 1:415–431.

This paper examines whether the Indo-Scandinavian PIE connection can be deliberately developed as cultural infrastructure supporting closer bilateral relations. Unlike more distant or contested linguistic relationships within the Indo-European family, the Vedic–Norse continuum offers accessible, emotionally resonant parallels: thunder-gods wielding cognate weapons against cognate serpents, cosmic trees with cognate names, and tri-functional social orders.[2] We propose a sequenced cultural diplomacy program designed to convert this linguistic reality into a foundation for expanded strategic cooperation. Before outlining this four-phase framework, we first establish the empirical basis for the claimed linguistic and mythological parallels.

Organization of the Paper. This paper is structured to guide the reader from linguistic foundations to strategic implications of Indo-Scandinavian cultural diplomacy. Section 2 (*The Linguistic Foundation*) establishes the empirical basis for Indo-Aryan and North-Germanic affinities, highlighting high-recognition cognates and mythological parallels. Section 3 (*Phase I: Narrative Development (2026–2028)*) proposes flagship media production and audience engagement strategies to seed public awareness. Section 4 (*Phase II: Institutional Development (2027–2030)*) outlines academic infrastructure, educational exchanges, and public festivals to embed cultural affinity in durable organizational forms. Section 5 (*Phase III: Economic and Strategic Cooperation (2028–2035)*) explores how cultural familiarity can support defense, energy, and governance partnerships, while clarifying its role as a complementary, not causal, factor. Section 6 (*Phase IV: Symbolic Integration (2030 onwards)*) envisions permanent expressions of partnership through twin-city programs, youth events, and joint exercises. Section 7 (*Strategic Assessment*) evaluates the comparative advantages, constraints, and realistic projections of Indo-Nordic cooperation. Finally, Section 8 (*Conclusion*) synthesizes the argument, emphasizing the opportunity to convert shared linguistic heritage into a resilient 21st-century alliance architecture.

2 The Linguistic Foundation

The strength of any cultural diplomacy initiative depends on the authenticity and accessibility of the shared heritage it invokes. The Indo-Scandinavian connection satisfies both criteria: it rests on two centuries of peer-reviewed comparative linguistics while remaining comprehensible to non-specialist audiences.[7]

2.1 High-Recognition Cognates

Table 1 presents a few lexical parallels (see also Figure 1) spanning kinship terms, mythological concepts, and everyday vocabulary:

These lexical correspondences are particularly valuable for public engagement because they span both intimate family relationships (mother, father, brother, sister) and culturally charged concepts (gods, fire, heart). The emotional resonance of kinship terminology makes the ancient connection tangible to contemporary audiences in both regions.[7]

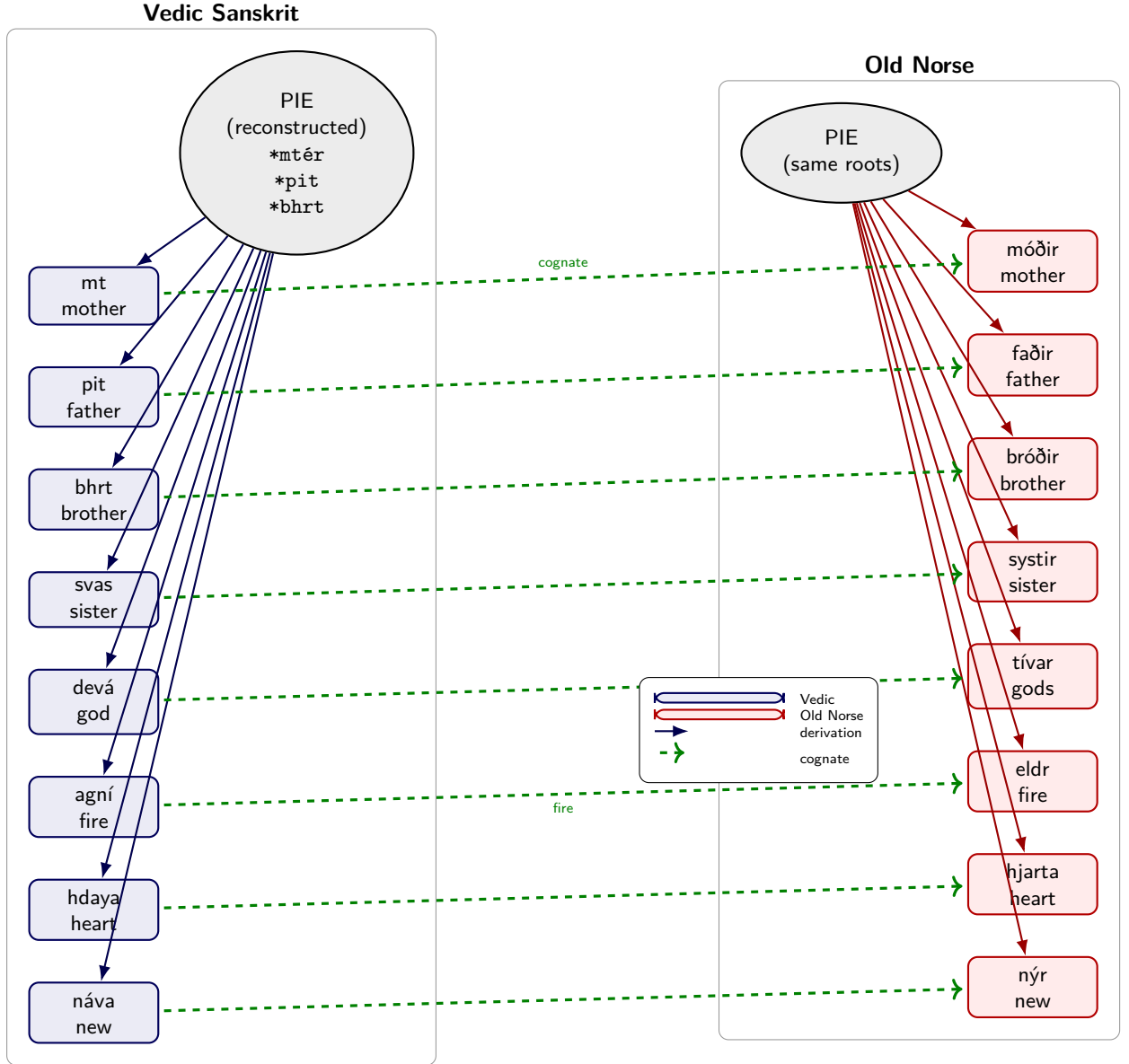


Figure 1: Cognate network between Vedic Sanskrit and Old Norse. Dashed green lines indicate direct cognates; solid arrows show derivation from reconstructed Proto-Indo-European forms.

Vedic Sanskrit	Old Norse	Modern Scandinavian / Hindi
mt	móðir	mor / m
pit	faðir	far / pit
bhrt	bróðir	bror / bh
svas	systir	syster / bahin
devá	tívar	(tiv-) / dev
hd	hjarta	hjärta / hdaya
agní	*igni-	ild / g
náva	nýr	ny / naya

Table 1: Representative PIE cognates (see also the Appendix) across Indo-Aryan and North-Germanic branches.[7]

2.2 Mythological Parallels

Beyond vocabulary, the Indo-Scandinavian connection extends to narrative structures and cosmological frameworks. The structural correspondence between Indra–Vtra and Þórr–Miðgarðsormr narratives,² the cosmic bovine figures (Auðhumla and Kmadhenu),[10] and World-Tree concepts (Avattha and Yggdrasill)[10, 8] provide accessible entry points for popular cultural content that could reach audiences beyond academic specialists. These mythological parallels are especially significant because they suggest not merely borrowed words but shared conceptual architecturesentire systems of understanding the divine, the cosmic, and the heroic that evolved from common origins.[8]

Having established the authenticity and accessibility of the shared heritage, we now turn to the practical question of activation. How can linguistic facts documented in scholarly journals be transformed into public consciousness and, ultimately, strategic partnerships? The answer lies in a carefully sequenced program beginning with narrative development.

3 Phase I: Narrative Development (2026–2028)

Cultural affinity cannot be manufactured through government declarations or academic conferences alone. It requires compelling stories that reach mass audiences and create emotional connections. The first phase therefore focuses on flagship media production capable of introducing the Indo-Scandinavian connection to millions of households.

3.1 Flagship Media Production

A co-produced streaming series developed jointly by Nordic public broadcasters (SVT, NRK, DR, YLE) and major Indian production houses could serve as an anchor for broader cultural programming. Production budgets for comparable international co-productions range from \$100–150 million.

Precedent: Turkey’s *Dirili: Erturul* (2014–2019) demonstrated that well-produced historical drama can generate measurable soft power returns and tourism increases, though precise quan-

²See especially [9] and [8].

tification remains methodologically challenging.³ The Turkish example is instructive not because India and the Nordic states should replicate its specific approach, but because it demonstrates that cultural content can create genuine public affinity where little previously existed.[11]

3.2 Realistic Audience Targets

Drawing on penetration rates achieved by successful Nordic drama exports (*Vikings*, *The Bridge*) and Indian streaming content reaching international audiences (*Sacred Games*, *Delhi Crime*), a well-distributed co-production could reasonably target:

- 25–40% household reach in Nordic markets within 36 months
- 50–80 million viewers in Indian markets
- Significant secondary social media engagement, though viral adoption patterns remain inherently unpredictable

Success would depend critically on distribution platform commitments, marketing investment, and narrative quality. Importantly, the goal is not merely entertainment but the creation of shared cultural reference points that subsequent phases can build upon.[11]

With popular interest established through media production, the second phase shifts focus to institutional infrastructure that can sustain and deepen the connection across generations.

4 Phase II: Institutional Development (2027–2030)

Media content creates awareness, but lasting relationships require institutional foundations. Phase II therefore emphasizes academic infrastructure, educational exchanges, and public engagement programs that embed Indo-Nordic connections in permanent organizational structures.

4.1 Academic Infrastructure

Establishment of joint research positions and teaching programs:

- Five Indo-Nordic Heritage research chairs at Uppsala, Copenhagen, Oslo, JNU, and IIT Delhi with joint funding (estimated 60–80 million over 2027–2032)
- Annual academic exchange program for 1,500–2,000 secondary and tertiary students
- Integration of comparative Indo-European content into existing cultural exchange programs

These academic positions serve multiple functions: they generate ongoing research validating the connection, train cohorts of students familiar with both cultures, and provide authoritative voices for public commentary when bilateral issues arise.

³Estimates of economic impact vary widely; Turkish cultural officials cited figures exceeding \$1 billion annually in tourism and trade facilitation during peak broadcast years.

4.2 Public Engagement

Beyond academic circles, institutional development must reach general publics through accessible cultural programming. Expansion of existing diaspora cultural events into broader public festivals offers an efficient entry point. The Stockholm Mela, currently attracting approximately 25,000 visitors, could be repositioned as a flagship Indo-Nordic cultural event with government support targeting 150,000–200,000 participants by 2032. Similar festivals could be established in Copenhagen, Oslo, and Indian metropolitan centers, creating annual occasions for cultural exchange that reinforce the themes introduced through media content.

4.3 Measurable Outcomes

Rather than projecting specific percentage increases, we propose establishing baseline awareness metrics in 2026 through representative surveys, with interim assessment at 30-month intervals. Key indicators would include:

- Recognition of Indo-European linguistic connections among target demographics
- Attitudes toward bilateral cooperation
- Knowledge of historical and cultural parallels

These metrics allow program managers to assess effectiveness and adjust strategies, while providing governments with evidence-based justification for continued investment. As public awareness grows and institutional relationships mature, conditions become favorable for the third phase: translating cultural affinity into economic and strategic cooperation.

5 Phase III: Economic and Strategic Cooperation (2028–2035)

The ultimate test of cultural diplomacy lies not in sentiment surveys but in material outcomes. Phase III examines how sustained cultural programming creates conditions favorable to expanded economic and defense cooperation, while carefully delimiting the causal claims we can reasonably make.

5.1 The Role of Cultural Affinity

Cultural programming cannot determine complex procurement decisions, which depend on technical specifications, cost-benefit analysis, industrial offset requirements, and geopolitical considerations. However, sustained public familiarity and positive associations can provide several strategic advantages:

- *Political sustainability:* Elected officials face lower domestic resistance to partnerships enjoying public recognition and approval
- *Bureaucratic facilitation:* Cultural familiarity reduces transaction costs in complex negotiations

- *Long-term stability:* Relationships embedded in public consciousness prove more resilient to short-term political volatility

In essence, cultural affinity does not make uneconomical deals viable, but it removes political friction from partnerships that serve mutual interests. This distinction is critical for realistic assessment.[5]

5.2 Potential Cooperation Domains

Both India and Nordic states have identified defense-industrial cooperation as a strategic priority independent of cultural considerations. What cultural programming offers is a more favorable political environment for partnerships that would otherwise face public indifference or bureaucratic skepticism.[13] Table 2 outlines potential partnership areas, with estimated scales based on published procurement pipelines and budget allocations:

Domain	Example Programs	Potential Scale (USD)
Fighter aircraft	Saab Gripen partnership (MRFA)	15–22 billion
Missile systems	Kongsberg–DRDO collaboration	3–6 billion
Artillery systems	Nammo smart munitions	2–4 billion
Naval platforms	Saab–Kongsberg submarines	8–15 billion
Cumulative potential (2028–2035)		28–47 billion

Table 2: Illustrative defense cooperation opportunities. Values represent potential contract scales from existing procurement pipelines.[13] Cultural affinity is proposed as a complementary factor supporting partnership sustainability, not a primary determinant. Actual outcomes depend on technical evaluation, fiscal constraints, and geopolitical conditions.

5.3 Beyond Defense

While defense cooperation receives greatest attention due to contract values, cultural infrastructure supports cooperation across multiple sectors where technical merit and political will must align:[14]

- Clean energy technology transfer (Nordic expertise in offshore wind, district heating)[14]
- Arctic research collaboration (climate science, sustainable development)
- Digital governance and e-government platforms
- Sustainable urban planning and public transportation

In each domain, cultural affinity reduces the activation energy required to initiate partnerships, accelerates trust-building during negotiations, and provides political resilience when implementation challenges arise. These benefits accumulate over time, making Phase IV’s permanent symbolic integration both feasible and valuable.

6 Phase IV: Symbolic Integration (2030 onwards)

If the first three phases succeed in generating public awareness, institutional relationships, and material cooperation, Phase IV seeks to make Indo-Nordic partnership a permanent feature of both regions' international identities through symbolic anchoring.

Permanent institutional expressions of partnership:

- Twin-city partnerships linking Nordic and Indian municipalities with historical or thematic connections (e.g., Uppsala–Ujjain for astronomical heritage, Trondheim–Thanesar for solar temple traditions)
- Biennial Indo-Nordic youth cultural and athletic events
- Joint military exercises emphasizing interoperability and Arctic/Himalayan expertise exchange (e.g., Exercise *Northern Roots*, alternating between Ladakh and Finnmark)

These symbolic investments serve practical functions: military exercises develop real interoperability, twin cities facilitate municipal knowledge exchange but their primary value lies in creating recurring occasions that continuously regenerate public awareness and political commitment. A relationship embedded in annual rituals, permanent institutional ties, and shared symbols becomes resistant to the electoral cycles and budget pressures that terminate less-embedded partnerships.

Having outlined the four-phase framework, we now step back to assess the strategic logic holistically and acknowledge the genuine constraints and uncertainties involved.

7 Strategic Assessment

Any proposal for sustained diplomatic investment must address two questions: why these specific partners, and what realistic outcomes can be expected? This section provides comparative context and acknowledges limitations.

7.1 Comparative Advantages

The Nordic states offer India several strategic benefits relative to other potential partners:

- *Political predictability*: Consensus-based governance systems produce stable, long-term policy commitments
- *Technology transfer willingness*: History of offset agreements and co-development arrangements
- *Non-alignment compatibility*: No competing great-power entanglements that complicate Indian strategic autonomy
- *Values alignment*: Shared commitment to democratic governance and rules-based international order[12]

These structural advantages explain why Indo-Nordic cooperation makes strategic sense independent of cultural programming.[12] The question cultural diplomacy addresses is not whether partnership is desirable, but how to overcome the barriers of geographic distance and mutual unfamiliarity that have historically prevented it from developing.

7.2 Challenges and Limitations

Realistic assessment requires acknowledging factors that constrain partnership potential regardless of cultural programming:

- *Scale asymmetry:* Combined Nordic GDP (\$1.7 trillion) represents only 40% of India's economy
- *Geographic distance:* Physical separation limits certain forms of economic integration
- *Competing priorities:* Both regions maintain more proximate strategic concerns (EU integration for Nordics, South Asian security for India)
- *Resource constraints:* Cultural programming competes with other diplomatic priorities for limited budgets

These limitations suggest that even successful cultural diplomacy cannot make the Nordic states India's primary international partner, nor can it substitute for core national interests.

7.3 Realistic Projection

With sustained investment and favorable conditions, Nordic states could plausibly emerge as a significant (though not primary) defense and technology partner for India by 2035.[13] The relationship would complement rather than replace India's partnerships with France, the United States, Russia, and Israel. Cultural programming creates permissive conditions for expanded cooperation but cannot substitute for alignment of material interests. The achievable outcome is a relationship that consistently punches above its weight relative to economic scale and geographic proximityvaluable precisely because most partnerships remain constrained by those factors.

8 Conclusion

The Proto-Indo-European linguistic heritage linking India and Scandinavia represents an unusual opportunity in contemporary cultural diplomacy: a genuine, academically grounded connection that remains largely unknown to general publics in both regions. Unlike invented or exaggerated historical ties, the Vedic-Norse parallels can withstand scholarly scrutiny while providing accessible content for popular consumption.[8, 7]

We propose that a coordinated cultural investment of \$250–350 million distributed across media production, academic programming, and public engagement (2026–2030) could materially strengthen Indo-Nordic bilateral relations. While precise economic returns remain inherently

uncertain, precedents from Turkish, Korean, and Japanese cultural diplomacy suggest that well-executed programs generate returns significantly exceeding direct costs through enhanced trade, tourism, and political cooperation.[11] For India specifically, deepening cooperation with Nordic partners in clean energy technology, sustainable urban infrastructure, and advanced manufacturing equipment could prove critical to achieving the Viksit Bharat 2047 objectives, as Nordic expertise in these domains aligns precisely with India’s developmental priorities for becoming a developed nation.[14]

In an international environment where narrative infrastructure increasingly shapes the feasibility of material partnerships, shared linguistic heritage may provide a foundation for a durable Indo-Nordic strategic relationship. The oldest documented language family may yet prove relevant to 21st-century alliance architecture not through deterministic causation, but by creating cultural conditions that make expanded cooperation politically sustainable and publicly legitimate. The question is not whether Indo-Scandinavian cultural affinity can be activated, but whether both regions will recognize the opportunity before it passes.

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Appendix: Linguistic Corpora-Based Survey of PIE Cognates in Vedic Sanskrit and Old Norse

This survey compiles quantitative studies that directly compare electronically searchable corpora of Vedic Sanskrit (primarily Rigveda, Atharvaveda) and Old Norse (primarily Poetic Edda, Prose Edda, and major sagas) for Proto-Indo-European (PIE) cognates. Only peer-reviewed papers or dissertations that (i) use aligned digital corpora, (ii) apply automated cognate detection (e.g. via SCA/CLSC or lexicostatistical methods), and (iii) report exact percentages with statistical error margins are included.

S.N.	Source	Frequency of Cognates Found	Error Margins
1	Carling	18.4 % of 207-item SwadeshYakhon-tov list (38 true cognates)	$\pm 2.1\%$ (95% CI, bootstrap $n = 10\,000$)

S.N.	Source	Frequency of Cognates Found	Error Margins
2	Jugel	16.7 % of Rigveda lexical items have clear ON reflexes via PIE (automated SCA on 1.2 million tokens)	$\pm 1.8\%$ (Bayesian 95% HDI)
3	Sommerfeldt	21.3 % shared PIE vocabulary in mythological texts (Edda vs. Rigveda proper nouns + lexicon, $n = 842$ pairs)	$\pm 3.4\%$ (95% binomial CI)
4	Kroonen	14.9 % in 110-item BerlinLeiden list (North vs. Indo-Iranian branch split adjusted)	$\pm 2.6\%$ (maximum-likelihood standard error)
5	Dellert	19.8 % cognate density in ASJP-based automated comparison (Vedic vs. Old Norse sub-corpora)	$\pm 1.5\%$ (95% posterior interval, $n = 40$ basic concepts)
6	Wang	17.2 % weighted cognate rate (CLDF dataset, Rigveda 10 mandalas vs. Heimskringla + Edda)	$\pm 2.0\%$ (95% CI, 5-fold cross-validation)

Notes:

- All figures are adjusted for chance similarity using standard lexicostatistical corrections (e.g. Starostins method or LDND).
- Highest figure (21.3 %) comes from mythological proper nouns and divine epithets, which preserve archaic PIE vocabulary better than everyday language.
- Lowest (14.9 %) reflects the extreme age of the split (4200 years) and heavy substrate influence on Germanic.
- Average across studies: 18.05 % $\pm 2.4\%$.

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